

lem rather than selling inputs in silos.” Finally, he lays emphasis on the scale accruing from real assets and capability depth.

“India has high agro-chemical diversity and sensitive farmer economics. In such a scenario, the ability to adapt formulations, improve efficacy and bring differentiated products quickly is a strategic advantage,” he says.

Each effort is an attempt to challenge the status quo and do different things. “We did not understand rock mining but got into it. We added capacities in sulfuric acid and phosphoric acid, which helped in creating the entire value chain and addressed the raw material need,” says Alagappan.

Together, those efforts have shifted the approach at the company. Take the case of the plant in Kakinada, Andhra Pradesh, which has transformed from one that was largely into mixing to becoming integrated. “With sulfuric and phosphoric acid, we are making complex fertilisers. Next year, it will become the single largest site for making phosphatic fertilisers in India,” says Alagappan.

On the retail side, its brand Gromor is opening a store a day and expanding reach. “As a company, we are highly entrenched in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana and touching the border markets of Karnataka and Maharashtra,” he says.

Plus, last March, Coromandel acquired a 53% stake in NACL, a crop protection company with a strong branded formulation business, for ₹820 crore. “We have got 14 new formulations plus fungicides. These are difficult businesses to build,” says Alagappan.

Those tracking the company seem to like the shift in the way the company operates. A Motilal Oswal report released in February after third quarter earnings said it is well-positioned to sustain the growth momentum in FY27 on the back of “favourable market dynamics, increasing shift

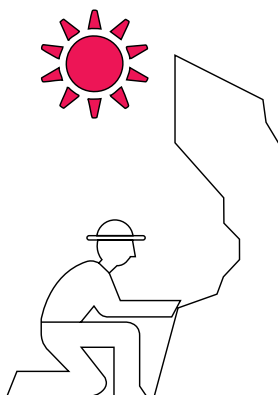
GETTING FUTURE READY

01 **Coromandel prides itself on being a “cost-effective player”**

02 **One of the key strategy components is backward integration to have a steady supply of raw materials**

03 **On the inorganic front, it invested in a rock mining company in Senegal and picked up NACL in the domestic market**

04 **Manufacturing excellence is the other important area, driven by innovation and removal of bottlenecks across plants**



towards NPK (nitrogen, phosphorus and potassium) fertilisers for balanced nutrition and strong growth in crop protection led by synergy benefits of the NACL consolidation.”

The medium-term outlook remains strong on account of five factors—expanding into new geographies, developing new molecules across fertilisers and crop protection segments, backward integration for the fertiliser business, purchase of NACL and scale-up of Senegal-based Baobab Mining and Chemicals Corporation.

Crisil Ratings says the NACL purchase was funded via internal cash accrual and Coromandel’s net liquidity after the acquisition stood around ₹450 crore as on August 31, 2025. “Given strong expected accrual and no significant debt-funded acquisitions, Coromandel’s financial risk profile is expected to remain strong. This acquisition augments the crop protection business, strengthening its presence in the domestic formulations business, expanding existing product portfolio and helping in securing contract manufacturing relationships with NACL’s established customers,” it said.

Alagappan stresses that Coromandel thinks like a tech company. “With predictive AI models, we are trying to see what kind of pests are present in an area,” he says. That is a reflection of the changing nature of the Indian economy. “Today’s farmer is younger and tech-savvy. I have seen some of them leaving IT and coming to farming.” That makes it vital for Coromandel to adapt to those for whom WhatsApp comes easily and technology is readily accessible. “These are not things that are nice to have. Rather, they are must-haves. Farmers are very advanced and do their research. Plus, they all use ChatGPT,” he adds with a smile.

For Alagappan, technology ties in neatly with his emphasis on making the firm stronger and more efficient. **BT**

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